

MOTHER'S MEMOIRS

*Compiled from the oft-repeated tales that have remained
through the years as vivid memories.*

Lottie Caton Abbott, 1948
Transcribed from the original typescript

FOREWORD

*The following pages would suffer greatly under the scrutiny of a literary artist; but, as the one spending much of my life so close to Mother, I have endeavored to leave to her children, who have known and loved her, and to all coming after, a true picture of her long and useful life, shot through with the color of historic years, and to do so simply, without dramatics or exaggeration, flattery, or criticism---
-Just the turning of the pages of her story; her life with its lights and shadows.*

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To give a true picture of Mother, (Mrs. W. B. Caton, nee Julis Charlotta Louisa Blankenmeister) it seems wise and fitting to look back and pick up a few of the threads that started the tapestry of her long and very useful life, most interesting to us, who have grown up around her, almost too close to get the fine perspective of time and distance.

Her mother, Louise Wettendorff, was the daughter of Bernard Von Wettendorff, Chief Justice of the courts, Trier, Germany, and Julia Louise Krum, for whom Mother was named.

This beautiful daughter of the distinguished family of the Von Wettendorffs, was trained in all the culture required of one of her station. Her home environment was of the socially and highly influential gentle folk, and was the gathering place of what we today choose to term the "intelligensia". Her uncle's estate in Trier was a show place of the city and was visited and enjoyed by some of our own Winfield boys during World War I.

Her sister (Grandmother's), whom we always have revered as our illustrious Tanta Fritsche, was the little fifteen-year-old girl of the golden voice, highly trained, who was chosen to sing the solo part in ELIJAH, Which was presented in Coblenz, the home of still another uncle of wealth and social position. It was the first performance of Mendelssohn's Oratoria, and he conducted it.

As was the usual custom, still popular among musicians, the soloists and artist musicians gathered after the concert in the home of Tanta Fritsche's uncle, in whose home she was a guest. So pleased had they been with her rendition of the difficult score, they asked her to sing it again.

"Oh, I can't. I have no accompanist," she demurred.

"I will accompany you," smiled Sphor, who was among the guests; and, after she had sung the difficult passages very beautifully, he, the great composer of violin and himself an artist, caught her up and, placing her on his shoulders, carried her to her chair. But she could not seek the concert stage; for that was not "Just nice", especially for girls of gentle birth.What a colorful biography could be written of this one of our forebears, who was "properly wed", then came to America with her husband and became an instructor of voice in Milwaukee. But that's another story.

This cultural background is sufficient excuse for some boastful moments in Mother's life, when she enjoyed telling of this aunt and the uncle who was "chief architect to the King of Bavaria" (Bill take notice) Just which king has never seemed important, at least,

whenever we shake the family tree, this information is never revealed. (Comparing dates, we think he was Charles VII of Bavaria)

Louisa's marriage (grandmother Blankenmeister) and just how it happened she married a tradesman--as you know, gentle folk do not engage in trade--she never was tricked into revealing. However, she married John Peter Blankenmeister, whom she insisted was an "artist", which in truth he was; for did not he design crown jewels? At one time, so Mother delights in relating, there was the chess set for the Czar of Russia, valued at a million and one-half rubles; at another, the bracelet of the Empress of Austria.

To us, American born, freedom-loving, convinced "little apples go to the bottom of the barrel", our heritage of this great patriot, his fearless stand for Lincoln against all but three other citizens of the hot-bed of Civil War, Booneville, Missouri, doubly proud to know that, though the other were ridden out of town in disgrace, he was left, "Because you are too valuable to our community to be spared", is far greater than had he been less a tradesman.

So John Peter Blankenmeister, trained for the priesthood, but unconvinced in his heart of their Catholic Creed, refused to accept the robe; rich in the heritage of artists, manufacturers, makers of toys and jewelry, and Louise Von Wettendorff, the beautiful daughter of the Chief Justice of the Court, reared in culture, a linguist, speaking five languages fluently, accustomed to formal parties, when her pretty feet were dainty in patent leather slippers and silk stockings, and her bare, white shoulders were protected by ermine-lined wraps, were married.

When Ferdinand, their first child was about a year old, they booked passage to sail from Amsterdam for that great country overseas, America. But, since the story is of their second child, Julia, born in St. Louis, April 4th, 1852, and who afterwards became our mother, I shall skip the details of the long, harrowing journey of three weary months' duration in a sailing vessel, as they most unfortunately missed the boat upon which they had engaged passage, and record as accurately as repetition makes possible, a few of the outstanding, indelible incidents of Mother's life, as recounted many times intimately and freely, and which I feel it my privilege to reserve for you, her children and grandchildren.

As I write Mother is approaching her ninety-fifth year, her mind as alert as, when a child of ten, she stamped her foot, while her dark eyes flashed fire, as the Southern soldier, who was snatching and grabbing all the valuables of her father's jewelry store; and, who perhaps as much to frighten the little girl of the North as to destroy, turned to the tall Grandfather clock and taunted: "I've a notion to smash it."

"Smash away," she retorted, making a face at him, "you've ruined everything anyway."

All of Mother's life until she was married, except for a few months as a baby before her parents left St. Louis, were spent in Booneville, Missouri, a very aristocratic river town, with slaveholders galore. It was here, as the daughter of a naturalized Bavarian, who swore allegiance to America, a staunch supporter of Lincoln's Republican platform and a sworn enemy of secession, she grew to womanhood, and around which the most interesting and colorful stories have been woven.

Reared on the principle that "all men are created free and equal", and no human being should be enslaved to another, it was with great pride that Mother told that her father had voted for Lincoln. What a calamity she set in motion! Within two hours a committee waited upon the "black Republican", ordering him to leave town. But, after talking with him, discussing the matter and realizing what a necessary person to the community he was, the only man who could keep their clocks ticking on time and their watches in repair: a valuable man and the father of six children, they decided to allow him to remain, provided he would not use his influence with the Negroes. So he, with his family, remained in Booneville; however, he remained loyal to his allegiance by raising the American flag (the Union flag) over his place of business, where it floated throughout the duration of the war, despite the fact men shot at it and women spit at it.

Many vivid pictures of Mother's life in those bitter days of the Civil War have been painted for us: her experience in the first Public School; the crudity of its equipment; the cruelty of the priest-teacher, and her withdrawal from the school because of it; the struggle to keep her in college, the Missouri Female College, a private school for girls; the dreadful day of bitter tears, when she could no longer continue. Grandfather's bank account was reduced as all others--war does terrible things, not only to people, morale, but pocketbooks-- and there were now three brothers and two sisters to be considered. Ferdinand must continue in Kemper Military School; for boys must have an education; girls, if the family purse would allow. But the darkest cloud has a backdrop of silver. Just when her much-longed-for education seemed at an end, the professor of the college--she names him yet with the greatest pride and reverence--called upon Grandfather to inquire why she was no longer in school.

"I cannot afford it", Grandfather explained.

"And we cannot afford to lose Julia from our school. If you will permit her to coach the French and German classes, we will credit her with full tuition."

So, at the age of fourteen, after two years of college work, Mother became a student teacher, continuing in the school until she graduated with honors.

College in its infancy was not the advanced school of learning of today, with its activities, curriculum and enlightening graphs. A student studied or she didn't; she advanced

or she didn't. There were few written tests in those days by which to determine grades. It was a complete surprise, therefore, when, at the end of the exercises, which answered as a commencement program, the professor, Professor Merrill, whose name Mother will never forget, rose and, addressing the audience, said:

"We have one student who has earned the honors of the school. Julia, will you come forward to receive your award?"

Almost too surprised; stunned, Julia felt she could not walk the length of the room to face the crowd and receive this unexpected honor, especially, as her knees were still weak from the shock from which she had not yet recovered. A shock, indeed! to take your place on the platform, paper in hand, to read the class history, only to discover you had picked up the wrong paper. The youthful mind is quick at mounting obstacles; easy at dissembling; so, though her performance had left her weakened, she had scored a real victory: standing, poised and apparently at ease, turning the pages like a finished performer, reading what appeared to be before her but, in truth, was in her head. Not one word did she omit, so well did she have her work prepared and committed.

All these and countless other interesting tales, Mother recounts of her girlhood, some exciting, some sad, but mostly of her carefree happiness, her insatiable desire for knowledge and her love for books and music; of the stolen hour of reading, since girls "should not be idle as long as it takes a bird to pick up a grain of seed".

One of the incredible stories Mother has reiterated countless times, concerns and reveals a girl's training when she was young: At the age of four she was taught to crochet and knit; and, according to her repeated avowals, she crocheted a cap for her baby sister, Wilhemnia (our aunt Mina) As I have never mastered the art of knitting, but do know some of the intricacies of crochet, I would be inclined to suspect the accuracy of Mother's memory; but, as she has ever been most truthful, we shall just accept the tale as further proof of her percocity.

In her girlhood home there was always a maid: the house work was a matter of perfect routine; linens were kept in perfectly smooth rows; mending was done before" laundry; in fact, Grandmother's housekeeping was an art, her handwork exquisite, the result of her training in the Convent in Metz, where she was educated; her meals were ever perfectly balanced, though in those days there was no talk of calories and carbohydrates; and her delicacies were not chance-whipped-up concoctions, but tested recipes, coming to her from the French and German cooks, chefs, she referred to them, in her family.

Mother delights to tell of the time when each girl in school was to bring cookies for a party. When Grandmother gave Mother the cookies she had made for her to take, there was a near scene. "I can't take these," she cried, "they are not pretty."

"I think they will like them," Grandmother insisted, and Mother went off rather downhearted. And did they like them! They ate them so fast, Mother did not even get a taste. No wonder. They were French cookies; something special for the occasion, first baked, then dipped in sugar and rose water. Delicious! Yes, but rough looking, no doubt.

So it never has been in our family: "As good as my mother could make", dropped so often half in jest and half in truth; but rather Mother's effort to bring to her family, her husband and children, the tasty and health-giving meals comparable to those upon which she was reared.

But as a girl Mother did little housework. Her duties lay mostly in knitting and sewing for the family. There were so many socks for three brothers and her father, and their shirts! My, those shirts! Made entirely by hand, the bosoms finely tucked and the cuffs and tails (not short ones as of today) to be blind hemmed.

Silver was very scarce in those days, but mothers are the same no matter what the century. A little coaxing, a veiled tip can do so much. This Grandmother knew and carried out so well by winding yarn, or cotton--all their stockings were knitted of finest cotton for summer and softest wool for winter) around a silver dime. How often Mother has recalled this one particular day, when she knitted a pair of socks. Such a task is almost an unbelievable feat of endurance and speed, but Mother accomplished it and was rewarded with the shining new dime; however, her happiness was marred somewhat by the severe scolding she received and the warning: "Don't you ever do such a thing again." In truth, Mother had learned that no dime is worth fainting over, which was just what she did when the last stitch was knitted off.

If stockings were knitted of cotton, each pair was numbered, numbers knitted in, and each girl should have at least one dozen pairs, and each was finished with a tape for tying them on. (Imagine our present-day legs, on display as they are, encased in home knitted stockings, tied on with a tape,) Fortunately, girls in those days wore long skirts.

But at the evening parties, and Mother had a very happy social life, always, of course, in company of her parents, who were leaders of the social set, one must be properly gowned. The evening frock must be low-necked and sleeveless, with always a cape or bolero to "cover the shoulders" except when dancing--- most careful were they of young girls when Mother was young.

Mother's party clothes always were worn with silk stockings and patent leather slippers. Such was the formal dress of Grandmother's girlhood, and she could never be persuaded to change it. Not all Booneville girls could go dressed in such finery, nor would Mother have been so fortunate, had it not been that Grandmother brought many lovely

things with her from the Old Country, among them, many pairs of white silk gloves, which, being a skilled needlewoman, she fashioned into evening stocking for her girls.

Mother, given a long life, has lived to experience the horrors and the heartbreak, the utter futility of four wars. The distance of the Spanish-American war, relieved of any personal hardship or sacrifice of her loved ones; the stories of the atrocities of World War I, and the unbelievable cruelties of World War II, while almost impossible of belief, indescribably sad, came to her indirectly, touching her more or less so, except for the heartbreak over the loss of her grandson, Captain Frank Pletcher Root, Jr. of the Air Service, World War II. But the Civil War was real. To a precocious child of eight, the cruel bloodshed and unbelievable atrocities of humanity gone savage, robbed her of much of a child's right to happiness and the sheer beauty of living.

"I saw many soul-searing, criminal acts under the guise of war, indelible scenes. War, when or where or for what cause, is ruthless; but when brother takes arms against brother; father against son, nothing can equal it.

"From the top of our house I saw the Battle of Booneville, fought between General Lyons on the Union side and General Price, Confederate, and had the thrill of witnessing the Union victory and watching General Lyons lead his men through the town. Defeat is necessary for one side or the other and never anything about which to be boastful, but to see a well-trained regiment of men running in every direction, as did Price's disrupted forces, was most amusing. To see men run! For the moment the horrors of the dead and dying were forgotten. To see men run! I was only nine, but capable of seeing the humor of the situation.

"The pedestal upon which I had placed my teacher crashed at my feet the day I visited her home to find her in the kitchen making pies for the soldiers. I was only a child, but when I saw her put ground glass into those pies, which I knew she intended to sell to the Northern soldiers, I ran as fast as I could to headquarters to report what I had seen and to warn them not to buy.

"The Bushwhackers were the ones we feared. They did the stealing. The general army appropriated supplies; horses, hogs, grain, corn; the Bushwhackers took our food and clothing, and destroyed and devastated as they pillaged. The Federal Army was supplied by the Government; the Southern Army had to get theirs as best they could. That does not mean the Union Army and its men were angels. Far from it. They often went on foraging jaunts--. soldiers, whatever cause they are upholding, seem to think the fact of their service absolves them from all law---great stories are told of their depredations.

"We resorted to all sorts of ways to protect our belongings. Mother and our maid, on this particular raid, put our clothes and valuables in sacks and hung them in a dry cis-

tern, We children were as much surprised to learn this as Mother was to discover the attempt my Brother Ferdinand and I made to help by slipping out all the valuables in father's store and burying them in the backyard. Had anything happened to us, their whereabouts would have remained a mystery. However, we were fortunate enough to be able to return them to their proper place. It was not unusual for us to wear several dresses, in that way we could save them.

"Standing out quite vividly in the raid, when Mother was so uneasy and alarmed, she took us all to a neighbor's for the night..... we girls were in constant danger.and when we returned the next morning, we found everything in disorder, every dresser drawer upside down, things strewn all over the rooms, and the mattresses full of holes, punched in by bayonets, even the pillows were spilling feathers; chairs were turned over, tables too. Not a possible hiding place of valuables had been missed.

"All these conditions of mental distress and fear were only surface troubles. Under all lay the hate engendered, when those on the Union side, those who voted for Lincoln, lived in constant dread and terror of what the day and the night held in horrible atrocity. Only a child and taking every word as truth, I believed my schoolmate when she said:

"I'm going to tell Bill Anderson, the Bushwhacker, your father voted for Lincoln and have him make shoes out of your hide."

"And the Negroes--Niggers, we called them-- Surely these were hectic days! So many Negroes were leaving their masters, running away to join the Union Army, and the poor, ignorant creatures were in mental turmoil. Being Lincoln sympathizers, we owned no slaves and always paid for any help we had from them.

"The unrest, the turmoil engendered a situation that was critical. In the hope of solving the problem, a mass meeting was called to discuss conditions and, if possible, ease the tension. The meeting was held in the Court House; and, though too young to be concerned with such profound questions, you may rest assured, I was there, right in the front row, both eyes and ears open to what was going on around me. Suddenly, I spied my father high up in the hall and realized he was rising to sing. I was startled, almost frozen with fear, as his beautiful voice pealed forth in the STAR SPANGLED BANNER.

The atmosphere was tense, and every moment I expected him to be shot down. Instead, there was a reverent silence as they heard him through. Maybe the only man in Booneville who voted for the 'Black Republican' was providentially spared!"

Those were stirring times, tumultuous, fraught with fear and heartaches. Life was at a premium; times were desperately hard; the value of the dollar greatly reduced, and few of them at that. But studying must be done and joy sifted out of the chaos as best one could.

Christmas came and must be made a happy time, though there were no dollars for toys. Few presents. But the old German custom remained a sacred event. In the Blankenmeister family Kriskingle came six weeks before Santa Claus. He came always to check up on the "good children" and to make his report to St. Nick.

Great tales have been told us of those days in Mother's childhood. Standing out most vividly and most often repeated was one when Christmas anticipation was so disturbed by the greatly changed financial status the war had brought on. Silver was so scarce; and Christmas, indeed, would be meager. There was only one gift that held any particular interest for Mother: THE MAIDEN'S PRAYER, a copy of which was on sale, but it was priced at seventy-five cents. Seventy-five cents! My, what a sum! That was a lot of money; but surprise of surprises! When Christmas morning dawned, in the toe of her stocking, Mother found fifty cents in silver. Why, that was worth seventy-five cents, the price of the coveted piece of sheet music. Without waiting to search further for any more gifts, off she dashed to buy a real Christmas gift; and before the day was over, she had committed the score; and, in passing, the story would lack much of interest were I to fail to report that now, at ninety-five, Mother enjoys nothing better than to go to the piano to play, not missing a note, this girlhood much-loved selection.

Many hideous pictures were indelibly imprinted upon the impressionable mind of the little girl, pictures too ugly and acts too beastly to record against our own American men, Christian men, many of them, whom war delights to change into savages; so, though all have been told again and again, less harrowing tales are best. Why hand down the horrible moments when there are so many interesting and beautiful memories to keep alive through repetition?

The one about Lincoln's second inaugural celebration, for instance; a true picture of those stirring times, so packed with the depression and exhilaration of history in the making.

Lincoln had been re-elected. The war was over. Southern soldiers had returned to their homes in the South. The Negroes had been freed from slavery; and Missouri, the one Southern state that had not seceded, was preparing for a truly great celebration, not only honoring Lincoln's inaugural, but to break the tension of the four years yet so close, and to make merry over victory.

Mother was in her twelfth year and had made herself a new dress for this particular occasion. Looking about us today, twelve seems very young, indeed, for a girl to be designing and making her own clothes; but we must remember that Mother had lived through four years of the horrors of war. Conditions had developed her far beyond her

years. So the pretty dress, with the low, drooping shoulders and the ankle-length skirt, was in readiness for the great day.

Flags were flying from every housetop. Candles illumined the windows, hundreds of them. Yes, though there was no electricity, the town was to be ablaze with light. Torches were made ready for the parade, and the great day dawned. But the candles were left unlighted; the flags were lowered to half-mast, and the gayly decorated streets and business houses were, in the twinkling of an eye, draped in heavy black.. "LINCOLN IS DEAD. SHOT DOWN AS HE ENTERED THE THEATER BOX WITH HIS WIFE! The news flashed around here, there, and everywhere, winging its way rapidly, as all bad news has a way of doing. The gala day became one of mourning, and the pretty dress, so carefully fashioned from ten whole yards of material at fifty cents a yard, was saved for some later festivity.

At thirteen, Mother--long, long before she was our mother, of course--was very busy with her studies in the college, working hard at her student teaching and, at the same time, keeping her place at the head of her classes. Often during the evening hours, it was her duty to stay in the store while Grandfather was out to his supper....those were the "good old days" when stores remained open after supper, as the evening meal in the small towns was called. Those were not idle, but golden, hours for Mother. When customers were scarce, her knitting needles clicked as rapidly as her eyes scanned the pages of her text books, set up before her. Little did she dream that Cupid's dart was aimed directly at her window. But it was; that is, the young Union soldier, the little seventeen-year-old bugler, of the Second Missouri Cavalry, just home after four years' service, looked in on the pretty brown-haired, red-cheeked girl, wholly unconscious of his gaze, looked and knew he had found the one that some day he would marry.

Then followed the days when "that blonde returned soldier, Billie Caton" kept following her. And was she disgusted! Indeed, so much so, that one day, when she was annoyed beyond control, she turned and made a face at him.

Then came the day of the Sunday School picnic, a picnic of Mrs. Aaron Caton's class(our Grandmother Caton), of which Mother was a member. "The picnic was out in Trigg's pasture, and who should arrive on the scene but Billie, looking like he had just stepped out of a bandbox. Quite the Beau Brummel and the catch of the town, but to me, he was a very presumptuous fellow, and I would have nothing to do with him" Cupid smiled. "But when it was my time to take the swing, horrors of horrors! he caught the swing and deliberately ran under me. I was so angry, I jumped from the moving swing and right into Cupid's arms. Billie picked me up, most solicitous; very sorry. In

fact, he scolded me for doing such a dangerous thing. That was how our introduction came about and our courtship began."

It was four years later, however, their marriage, rather elopement, occurred, 1869. Their courtship was true to the old and trite saying: "The course of true love never runs smoothly." Their meetings were of necessity clandestine, as Mother and Dad Blankenmeister, addressed in those days as mama and papa, would have none of him. "Who was he? He didn't have anything upon which to support a wife; and, besides, if you marry him, you'll be a widow within a year."

Not very bright prospects upon which to build a happy life; in truth, four years of service in the Union Army, lack of proper food for a growing boy--he was only thirteen when he enlisted-- and a long and serious siege of typhoid fever, had left him thin and entirely too white for robust health. But love laughs at obstacles and often sees deeper into the future than wise and over-considerate parents.

So Willie and Julia found many happy moments together, despite family disapproval, and they plighted their troth in the old Thespian Hall, Booneville, Missouri, when they were attending a dancing party. Both were as light as feathers on the dance floor, and must often have been much admired.

As so often happens parents' disapproval and their refusal to go along with young people and their love affairs, instead of against them, play into Fate's hands, as it certainly did in this instance. Often, too, parents live to "eat their words", as so happened much sooner than the irate mother and father ever dreamed they would. Who could know that Grandfather would fall ill of pneumonia, failing to recover; and, at the early age of fifty, leave his wife and a large family of dependent, half-grown children! Little did anyone dream that the one who would leave their daughter "a widow before a year had elapsed and never would make her a decent living", should one day welcome his widowed mother-in-law and her daughters into his own home and very gladly keep the home fires burning for them until such time as her sons could extend the needed shelter. His full forgiveness and reward came when Grandmother kissed him goodbye;, with tears brimming in her eyes and arms close about him said: "You have been better to me than any one of my sons, Willie"

An elopement is nothing unusual, nor would Mother's unexpected and hurried decision to "Leap and look afterward" have been any great event, nor worth recording, but for some of the truly funny incidents surrounding it; stories that have been told over and over, never failing to bring forth a chuckle.

Underlying all the humor, however, there were many frightening moments for one so young to face, and underneath lay the pathos of a real crisis: the breaking of home ties;

the making of a new life, and the uncertainty of what it held.

Mother had finished college and was teaching in the country, acting as governess, or rather as tutor, in a farmer's family. Soon her ability was noised about and others wanted her to instruct their children. So it was arranged that the teen-agers from other farms be allowed to come for instruction; thus she found herself with a class and, incidently, an increase in salary.

On week-ends she could go home, returning to her classes on Monday.. As there was no other mode of transportation, and there were miles between her home and the farm, the good, kind farmer took her back and forth on his horse, Mother sitting sidewise behind. Not too pleasant, especially in the early hours of a winter morning, but she was young and very ambitious.

When spring came, this particular spring in 1869, Mother arranged to stay on the farm to help with the spring sewing. Thus it was in March, "when the air was like wine", quoting her oft-repeated words, "Willie, who had secured a very good position in Sedalia, Missouri, and was bending every effort to prepare a suitable and comfortable home for us, when we planned to marry; for only when that time came did we intend to take the step, suddenly appeared at the farm to pay us a visit."

Booneville was a small town, not different from other small towns; and soon the news took on a grapevine rapidity: "Willie is in town."

As soon as this news reached the ears of Mother and Father Blankenmeister, things began to happen. A note was sent out to the farm; a note secure in the hands of her two young brothers. A note of warning: "Come home at once."

As it so happened, Willie had only arrived, when the boys were spied only a short distance away coming slowly down the road, astride a horse. The moment was tense. The happiness of two very-much-in-love young people was being closely watched; and, if her parents could have their way, and they were doing everything possible to achieve it, this love affair would be nipped in the bud. Had it not been for the friendly trees that screened Willie's pony from view and the motherly farmer's wife, who loving them both very much, kept Willie hidden until the boys could be sent back home, this story may never have needed telling, at least, not to us.

Knowing Mother as I do, her inability to dissemble, her frank, open countenance, I always have marveled that she kept her expression blandly innocent during those few moments of secrecy.

Willie's visit was short, but it was worth the sorrow of parting, since it held a promise to "come again soon". How soon neither guessed at the time. Life is like that. The greatest decisions are so often made suddenly.

Willie waved goodbye, and Julia went to her room, no doubt to cry it out. She took down her soft brown hair, that hung below waist, to give it its hundred strokes, when there was a soft knock at the door.

"Why, come in, Mrs. Wilson", Julia exclaimed in a surprised voice. "Is anything wrong?"

"N-o-o," Mrs. Wilson whispered. "Willie is down stairs and wants to see you."

"But I can't see him this way," Julia replied in alarm.

"Oh, yes, hurry into something; he hasn't much time. I'll send him up." and Mrs. Wilson slipped away, leaving Julia agast.

Their moments alone were, as always, their own; but when Willie left he had Julia's promise to be ready early the next morning, when he would return to Tipton, where they would be married.

"There is no need to postpone our marriage longer," persuaded Willie. "You are unhappy, and so am I. We'll just marry and end all this interference and trouble."

There were many tears and protests from Julia, but Willie's arguments were too convincing for a young girl, head-over-heels in love.

The spring rain fell softly as an accompaniment to Julia's tears, that dropped into the tub, where she was rinsing out a few underthings--not lovely soft silk lingerie of today, but plain cotton: long skirts and heavy stockings. Why, she didn't even have her good clothes with her, just her every-day things! But Willie wanted her, "Just as you are", and that meant she must be married without any of the finery brides adore.

When the stage lurched to a stop before the farm house gate, nearing six in the morning, the horses, four, driven tandem, were covered with mud but "rarin' to go." Julia, as promised, was ready--incidentally Mother never was late to anything in her life--attired in undies not too dry and her simple school dress, but looking "as pretty as a picture", to quote her abducting swain. Together they dashed through the pouring rain to the waiting stage, where to her surprise were Willie's sister Julia (Aunt Julia Sawtell) and his best friend, Billie Talleferro.

What a ride! Twice on the way to the little by-station, where they were to take the early morning train for Tipton, the horses mired, knee deep. Roads in Missouri in 1869 were not the streamlined concrete ribbons of 1947. Mother tells me that six-mile drive, when the stage lurched and groaned, all but turning over twice, "was the most harrowing experience of my life", and to her remains one of the vivid memories of her girlhood.

To make the experience complete and worth telling, still further depressing conditions hampered them. When at last they rocked to a stop at the wayside station, where the Tipton train was to pick them up, the agent had not yet arrived. The rain poured; the

eaves of the small station were little protection, hardly enough. By the time the train rolled in, they were nicely soaked. But they were young, and one does not elope every day.

At Tipton the girls spent the time Willie and Billie were getting the license and finding a minister, preparing the bride for the ceremony. Nothing would do but that Aunt Julia's lavender dress must be substituted for Mother's plaid. (Aunt Julia was wearing lavender for her mother. It was the custom then to go into mourning for your loved ones, first wearing black, then lavender, and lastly white. After this period of months, it was quite proper to resume the usual wearing apparel.) Whether or not the girls thought of this is beside the point. Julia could not be married in a plain woolen plaid dress. That was that. But, as they were not the same size, there was of necessity much tightening here and letting out there. All very exciting and a perfect rouge for Julia's pretty cheeks. Then a hat. "You can't be married in a nubia," declared Aunt Julia. "I'm going out to find you a hat." But her search was fruitless. "This is the worst town I've ever been in," protested Aunt Julia. "There's not a hat to be had, at least, not one fit for a bride," she declared, much disappointed over her unsatisfactory quest.

But Julia (Mother) had more serious things to think about. Willie and Billie were back, looking very wise, and in all seriousness telling her she would have to put the figure eighteen in her shoe.

"Why do I have to do that?"

"So you won't have to tell the judge a story. You'll be over eighteen, won't you?" Then they laughed at the foolish little bride, Who believed so implicitly in others' honesty, she had not caught the joke being played on her. Not yet seventeen, she could easily believe there was a law requiring eighteen necessary for permission to marry; that is, without parent's consent; and, if there was to be any deceit, she would have none of it.

And so they were married in the hotel parlor. No one was to know anything about it, but the bell boy couldn't keep a secret. The news leaked out, and the blushing bride had to face a whole room full of most inquiring eyes, as she, with her new husband, entered the dining room for what, though not especially prepared, became her wedding supper.

Then it was time to go to the station to take the train for Sedalia, where Willie was employed in the monumental business.

[PAGE 24 MISSING]

The original typescript's page 24 is missing from the scan (the scanned file contains page 21 twice instead). The text resumes below at the start of page 25.

Nothing of which to be very proud, except that it was a gift. Just a walnut table, not very pretty and quite old. Little did Mother dream that it would occupy an especial place in her large, well-furnished living room, seventy-five years later, and that her daughters and grand-daughters would each want to claim it.

In Sedalia, where Mother taught music to add to the family bank account and, incidentally, keep her fingers nimble and her technic smooth, her first child was born, January 26, 1870, just two months before she was eighteen. And were they proud of their beautiful boy, whom they named Harry Aaron. It is not such a stretch of imagination, but a delightful one, to drop back across the years to see the young mother sitting out on the little stoop of the humble home in "Cotton's Addition", picking her guitar as she sang "I Cannot Sing the Old Songs" or "Kathleen Mauverneen", while the adoring husband, tired after a long day at the bench, carving marble, relaxed close by to watch the pretty picture of his rosy-cheeked wife and his handsome son. A pretty picture, indeed.

After an unsuccessful venture into another kind of work, which took them to St. Louis in the third year of their marriage, an opening presented itself in Warrensburg. Here they stayed for six years, finding some of their happiest days and their first sorrow. It was here, in "Old Town", their baby girl was born, December 7, 1871. She was a beautiful, golden-haired, blue-eyed baby, as lovely as her name, Flora. But at thirteen months, they lost her. Only those who have had a similar grief can understand the heart-break of giving up a precious baby, and they were so young.

One year later, December 25, 1873, to keep dates correct, Santa Claus, knowing how lonely they were without little Flora, left another little girl under the Christmas tree. At least, that is the story that has become tradition in my life. Yes, it was Lottie, their third child, named Lottie Lee by our beloved Uncle Albert, who was living with Mother and Dad at the time. Mother held out for Charlotte after her, but Dad would have no nicknames in his family, and Charlotte would certainly call forth something more affectionate, which would mean a nickname. So Uncle Albert, up on all the popular songs of the day, said: "If you name her Lottie, it must be Lottie Lee", which was a song he was singing all the time. Thus Lottie Lee became my name.

During the six years in Warrensburg, Mother had no piano, but it took her little time in Butler, where they moved about 1876, to renew her practice and secure a large class of pupils. In her scrapbook there is a program, dated 1877, of which she is very proud. The program is of a concert, today called a recital, of her student's work. The concert was given in the Presbyterian Church; and, but for one number, would be just another program; however, among those appearing were her son, Harry, and her three-year-old daughter, Lottie, singing a duet: "Where Are You Going My Pretty Maid". Of this I have a

dream-like recollection, but it seems I made my bow at a very early age, scoring quite a hit and some few curtain calls--a matter of much pride to my young, adoring parents.

Again they turned from the monumental business for what seemed far better and exactly the work for which they had been searching. It had seemed such an easy thing for Mother to place pianos with her students, why not go into it right, make selling pianos a business. And that is what they did.

Disposing of the marble business, they launched into an entirely new venture. From door to door Mother sold sheet music, which, of course, she could play so entertainingly, she became a very helpful business associate. But this entailed travel and, with two small children to be considered, wasn't very much to the liking of such home-loving people and, therefore, could not last long. Thus, when a good opening presented itself in Clinton, where there was a vacancy in a marble shop, once more "Willie was back in the monumental business." 'There is a destiny that shapes our ends' seemed to be proving true in their lives; for, try as they would, Dad always was back in the marble business in some capacity, whether at the bench or as owner of the works.

Their stay in Clinton, however, was short. "Wanderlust caught up with my husband, and 'Go West young man' was too strong for him to resist, so we started for Kansas. Having spent sixtytwo years in 'sunny Kansas', all of them in Winfield, perhaps the Fates had a purpose in buffeting us about" quoting Mother's own words.

There were many tears and protestations over this move, but all arguments proved of no avail. "Kansas was the place for young men". When goods were crated for shipment and everything in readiness to start, even train connections checked, in walked "Willie's Brother Henry from Booneville, with the sad news that the doctor had not only advised but warned that he must get out-of doors or life would be cut short for him." How unexpectedly and suddenly plans can be changed. If Henry needed out-door cure, what better way to get it than by overland to Kansas?

The tears that had been copious before were bitter now. By wagon to Kansas! Kansas of itself was bad enough, but to go there in a mover wagon, that was a pill almost too bitter to swallow. But Henry was young. He was ill and much loved. His life hung in the balance, so overland it must be.

Thus it was that the "prairie schooner" was equipped for a family of five, Mother and Dad, Harry and Lottie, and Uncle Henry, a very ill young man. That journey through sunshine and rain, dust and mud; meals cooked by the roadside over smoky fires; the the long evenings, when darkness made travel impossible, and the time was spent in a three-sided game of casino, played under a sputtery lantern, hanging from a rib of the cover, remain incidents in one interval of two young people's lives much richer to look

back upon than to experience. Many stories are told of happenings along the way, some tragic; other, funny--..

That night, when Uncle Henry became suddenly ill, so very ill, Dad had to walk into town for a doctor, while Mother watched flood waters rising all too quickly, momentarily edging too close to the wagon. And the days of delay, as Uncle Henry was too ill to travel. Anxious days that ended at last, and again the journey was continued. To be sure the clothes and bedding showed signs of heavy drenching suffered from flood waters, and Mother was a little more depressed.

Altogether it was a leisurely trip, packed with interesting sights of new country and people. Occasionally it became necessary to stop for provisions, which brought about one of the most laughable incidents of the whole trip and bore out the feelings that were rankling deep in Mother's heart.

This particular time there was a real need of corn for the horses--three in all--so, approaching a very prosperous looking farm home, they stopped to inquire whether or not they could buy some of the corn that was fairly bursting from the cracks of the granary. As the farmer packed the sacks with the rich, golden product of Missouri, conversation naturally followed:

"Where you goin', pardner?" questioned the farmer.

"We're on our way to Kansas," was Dad's proud reply.

Without a word, the farmer turned and emptied the sacks, then, with a withering look of disgust, exclaimed:

"No fool on his way to Kansas can have any of my corn. Drive on."

And drive on they did, chuckling over one good story they would have to tell their grandchildren.

At every stop they mentioned their possible destination as Wichita, but were always met with the same surprising advice: "That beautiful little town of Winfield, that's where you should go. They say that's the best town in the state."

Whether it was destiny that held the reins and guided these overland wayfarers into the thriving little town of which they had heard such intriguing reports, or their curiosity to see for themselves whether all they had heard was true or false, remains a secret of the Fates; nevertheless, it so happened their weather-beaten "prairie schooner" rocked slowly down the peaceful street of Winfield on Sunday, October 25, 1879, just as the churches were dismissing their worshipers. From the rear of the canvas-covered wagon, four pairs of inquiring eyes looked with amazement upon the happy, well-dressed crowds pouring from the several churches. What a wonderful town to be only ten years old!

On south they drove, across the rustic, two-span bridge, stretching its accommodating length across the pebble-bottomed stream, they afterwards learned was the Walnut. Then farther on around and up the hill to the cemetery, now known as Highland, as, of course, Dad was greatly interested in a town's burying ground. From this high point they looked down on the tree-lined streets of the peaceful little city, which Mother has ever declared was one of the prettiest sights she ever had seen.

"Why should we go to Wichita? They say it is such a rough western town. A post where cowboys gather to get drunk and carouse," Mother ventured.

"There's no particular reason. This seems like a truly thriving little town," Dad agreed.

"Then let's stay here," Mother begged.

So it was the decision made on that perfect fall day so many years ago became the keystone of their life in the West and established another new family in the growing little city of Winfield, Kansas.

Driving back down the hill, across the romantic bridge, they continued north along Main Street, where they camped, (its being Sunday and not the proper time to search for a house) on the commons at the point which now is the southeast corner of Fifteenth and Main Streets. Across the street north there is a "filling station today, but then there stood a large brown house in which we found our first friends, the George Millers. They had two daughters, Anna and Mabel. But for the kindness of Mrs. Miller, Mother would have shed many more tears. Incidentally, Mabel Miller was born in this house, and fifty years later took a bow and received the honors of the city, as the oldest and only one born here, and who still resided in her birthplace.

After her many friends left behind in Missouri and the beauties of the old, well-established towns, such as the one it had been her pleasure to enjoy, Winfield, though quite progressive for its ten years of growth, was not a soothing salve for Mother's nostalgia. Streets were lacking the cobblestone of eastern towns. Cobblestones at best are nothing over which to rejoice, nor are they particularly pleasant walking aids; nevertheless, at their roughest, they are an improvement over mud and dust, of which this Kansas town had an abundance.

Houses, too, were as scarce as in the present-day housing shortage, so it was several weeks before temporary quarters were found and the old, weather-stained covered wagon could be abandoned for rooms in what passed as a family hotel, known as the Elder House. This hotel was quite conveniently located for Dad's plans, as he was, of all things, opening a grocery store. Again he was pulling away from his original business and was investing the few thousand dollars he and Mother had so carefully and patiently

accumulated in the ten years of their marriage. "All people eat", Dad argued. "There's money in groceries." Perhaps so for one who understood the tricks of the trade and lacked a heart that melted at every hard luck story, but a sorry venture for Dad.

THE ONE HORSE GROCERY was a nice little store with shining windows and a beautiful prancing horse atop the front door, located across the street from our present-day Regent Theater.

As no home was to be found, a room was added back of the store, where, with her piano and a few of her pretty things, Mother arranged living quarters for her little family. How the wind blew in those days! Or was it that there was nothing to break its force? No paving to keep down some of the dust? And what a task it was to keep her white beds free from the dirt that blew in so distressingly through the cracks in the poorly constructed "lean-to", which was the best that could be gotten at the time.

Those were trying days, but despite the hours needed to help in the store, Mother found time to write a letter to the TOLEDA BLADE, telling of her trip to Kansas and what she had found here. She had promised her Missouri friends she would write them and took this way of reaching all of them and giving in detail her experiences during her overland journey. It was written with the hope all her friends would get a real pleasure in hearing news of the trip--she had been writing for the BLADE before leaving Missouri--but little did she dream of what far-reaching results she had set in motion. At least once in her life Mother experienced the thrill, or annoyance, whichever it proved to be, of fan mail. Over a hundred letters reached her, some asking for more information; others, taking her flash of humor that "In Kansas there is no stock law, so stock is allowed to run loose. I saw pigs tied by their tails and cows by their horns." Only a half-truth, but did it boomerang! "Were there Indians?" "Would she tell them more?" One man waxed sentimental and proposed marriage. He "knew just how she looked"; and, strange as it may seem, Mother declares he described her quite accurately.

Not only did her letter bring surprising repercussions from the readers of the BLADE, but the city editor, Mr. Conklin, who was publishing the paper that afterward became the COURIER, asked Mother to write articles for his paper; also the lawyer, Mr. Green, offered her twenty-five cents for every letter she would write, enclosing one of his leaflets promoting Winfield. This she did for some time, picking up quite a few dollars in the moments she could snatch from her housework and the weighing of sugar and coffee.

Busy days full of worry over Uncle Henry, who grew steadily worse; and, at last, left them to return home. "I want to die there," he said, which he did very soon after he arrived in Booneville.

Dad's belief that all people eat proved true as far as the ONE HORSE GROCERY was concerned, but he had yet to learn that, though all people eat, not all people pay. Before he realized what was happening, his investment had been absorbed and his balance sheet was far in the red. Only a year, one of hard work and high ambitions, but he had been far too credulous. The day came when he could no longer satisfy his creditors, nor could he collect from his charge accounts, which, of course, added up to ruin. As young as I was, I shall never forget that day and the look of utter dejection on Dad's face. All his savings gone, the sacrifices of ten years, gone! Which way should he turn?

So the ONE HORSE GROCERY store folded up. However, he had not dealt with wholesale marble men for ten or more years for nothing. His credit with them was gilt-edged, and "he could have all the marble he wanted and all the time necessary in which to pay for it."

Once again he was back in the monumental business, this time to stay. Never again would he look for greener fields. Experience is a great teacher, harsh at times; but Dad had learned his lesson. From this day on, 1880, he would stay in the marble business. That Caton Marble Works is known and respected not alone in Kansas but adjoining states, and that the business was carried on as the firm of Caton and Son (Harry being the son) for more than sixty years, is sufficient proof of its success.

But in 1880 Mother and Dad found themselves, to use the common phrase, "broke," in a strange town, without friends, and with two children to rear and educate. However, they were young. They had each other. Dad was not afraid of work and was teeming with ambition, and there was Mother, always resourceful. She would turn back to her teaching, her most loved work.

That meant she would have to arrange her household duties so she could attend normal. It would mean many hours of study, reviewing those subjects long laid aside: "readin', writin', and rithmetic". Only that way could she secure a certificate and perhaps a position in the city schools.

It was not long after she entered normal that her outstanding ability was noted, not long until she was called upon to write themes on this subject and that; and, if there was some especial gathering, she not always was asked but chosen to make the address. This added much to her already heavy duties; but, as always, it reacted greatly in her favor, especially as she passed her tests most successfully and secured a position in the city schools.

"It was in September, 1880, I received my certificate to teach in the Public Schools and was given the primary department, then in the Central Building, long since razed. I

began with one hundred-twenty pupils. After a week of enrolling and planning, the Superintendent said:

"You are already worn out with this army of children. We must make a change. I shall divide the number, half to come in the morning; half in the afternoon."

"That was done, and for the first year I taught that way. Such an arrangement gave the pupils better attention, but was certainly very hard on me, as I was weary by noon, when sixty robust youngsters flocked in to be taught."

Mother's happiest memories are of those years with the little tots of Winfield. Many of them still live at the other end of her telephone and have grandchildren of their own.

With teacher's salaries of today inadequate, requiring, so it seems, a strike to lift them to necessary increase, Mother looks back to her teaching days, when her salary was forty dollars a month, which, if cashed when issued, required a discount of whatever per cent the banker chose to ask, often reducing the amount as much as four or more dollars.

During these years while Dad was establishing himself in business and Mother was teaching, the first home was bought. It was a little cottage at 1610 Millington Street, where we spent ten years of our childhood days, very happy days for Mother and Dad and their two children, Harry and Lottie, Mother found time, or took it, to have a small music class; a few summer students to coach in subjects in which they had failed, and also to devote much time to the cause of Temperance. Saloons were flourishing, giving the WCTU, of which Mother was one of the organizers, much to do.

Only a little child at the time, I still relive the thrill I had on that very hot summer day, when the twenty boys, whom Mother had trained to sing the Temperance song she had composed, march in uniforms, she had designed and mostly made, to the park, then the only one Winfield possessed, the beautiful, natural and most inviting Riverside. As the boys marched, dressed in their suits of red, white, and blue, holding high a flag, they sang, and HOW! At the park they filed on to the large stone platform, continuing to sing. It was touching and beautiful and an inspiring setting for Mother, who was one of the speakers of the day, as this picnic was planned to further the cause of Temperance, and how those early settlers worked!

By this time Dad was becoming quite well established; Mother's teaching continued and would have gone on much longer had not the stork sent word he was sending a new baby to live at our house.

It was not just as simple as that, however, for Mother, always frugal and ambitious, foolishly picked and canned a bushel of tomatoes right at the time when she should

have been taking care of herself. Consequently, for six weeks before the new baby arrived, October 8, 1883, christened Bonnie Louise, Mother lay at death's door.

Those were frightening weeks to a child of nine, especially, as there were no nurses or hospitals and few women who could be secured to help at such a time; but, as all things come to an end, whether good or bad, we managed through those days and were rewarded by the arrival of a little, a very little, girl baby, who weighed only two and one-half pounds; a real live doll for me, a much adoring sister, to rock and love very much. Despite the fact there were no incubators nor anxious nurses to watch over the tiny bit of humanity, she grew. Indeed, she grew and lived to become the mother of nine children.

These were busy years, full years for Mother with her growing family and mounting work. On the plot south of the house, Dad planted fruit trees: cherries, green-gage plums, pears, peaches, and even almond trees. There were strawberry plants, blackberry bushes, and both black and red raspberries, gooseberries and currants.

At the rear of the house stood the barn, where there was always a horse or two, and a Jersey cow. Oh, the thick, yellow cream for those berries, great luscious bowls of them.

Mother did the washing and ironing, churned the butter, except when I was put to the task, and there was always a flock of chickens; and, too, she carried on her summer school and her class in music. Somehow, she managed to attend normal for added credits, while, at the same time, acting as president of the Women's Relief Corps, an auxiliary of the G. A. R., which was organized about this time and was six hundred strong.

In 1886 Louis was born, and still there were no nurses or hospitals. A woman, a good friend of the family, had been engaged for the few weeks when help is so necessary; but she failed to appear. What a time we had! To tell of it is to record more or less a miracle, at least, the present-day health department would think so; but it proved that Mother was one in a million when it came to facing any situation and carrying it through successfully.

For a child of twelve, it was no easy task to care, as best she could, for a mother and the new baby, to keep meals ready for the family and the house in some sort of order. Normal conditions would have been no easy undertaking, but when Bonnie developed a fever, and my own throat was very sore--another attack of tonsilitis from which I suffered every winter--things went all wrong. Louis was fussy, no doubt not too warm, its being February and bitter cold. He could be kept quiet only when snuggling in Mother's arms. Bonnie made little trouble--she was such a patient child--but she was ill, so Mother took her in beside her. Then by the time I had prepared dinner for Dad and Harry, I was far too ill to carry on longer, so I crawled in beside Mother. Poor Mother!

How she endured it and came through without contracting the dangerous condition, aside from the discomfort of four in the bed, had a normal recovery and in ten days was mistress of her disrupted household, is beyond belief but proof conclusive that she knew no defeat.

It was in 1885, during her pregnancy for Louis, that Mother helped to organize the Degree of Honor and was made its first Chief. At the January meeting, 1886, "I initiated twenty-three members, doing the work without a book. Dr. Green, who had asked me to organize this auxiliary of the Modern Woodman, of which he was an officer, could not understand how I could memorize the Ritual for the initiation, which I did. 'A few days later I helped with a big dinner given by the W.R.C. for the G.A.R. That was the last appearance in public for me for sometime. I attended only one or two more Degree of Honor meetings. Dr. Green asked my husband why."

"Do you want her to have her baby during a meeting?"

'Baby! Where does she carry it? I'm a doctor, but I've never seen such a thing.'" quoting Mother's own words.

The familiar picture of the stork rushing along with the baby just ahead of the doctor, was no myth in Louis' arrival; in fact, the stork did beat the doctor to 1610 Millington on that cold day, February 27, 1886.

It was in 1888 that Mother was nominated for the office of County Superintendent of Public Instruction, on the same ticket with William Henry Harrison and was elected with a fine majority, then in 1889 took her seat to serve two years.

Victory naturally is very gratifying and one is excusable if, perchance, there is a hint of boastfulness; but in Mother case, there was only humble gratitude, which was shown so conclusively in the speech she made to the cheering crowd of well-wishers, who surrounded the little front portico of the humble cottage at 1610 Millington.

Impromptu speaking was something new to Mother; but, as usual, she was equal to the situation. Stepping forward, dressed in her becoming red dress, her lovely brown hair in double braids around her head, she surprised the waiting crowd by saying:

"My fellow citizens, I thank you for your loyal support throughout my campaign and successful election. My joy in victory is greatly dampened, however, by the thought of my opponent's defeat."

She spoke of her desire to fill the office successfully and that she would do all in her power to make a good superintendent. There were cheers and many congratulations, but her supporters never got over the fact that in her hour of triumph she thought first of the one defeated.

Her work as superintendent was heavy. There were fiftyone schools to visit; once a year a four-weeks' normal to conduct, and all the conflicts of rural disagreements to settle. While in office she introduced commencement of rural schools, she herself holding the first exercises in Island Park. This was the first presentation of diplomas to rural school students, and, so far as known, the first ever held in the state. From that date hence the pupils of Cowley County, who have completed their grade work, have been privileged to enter city high schools.

It was in 1890 that the little house at 1610 Millington was deserted for 1702 Millington, just two doors south. For a family of six the small cottage was a bit cramped; so, when the right moment came and the much-wanted house could be purchased, the house built by a man from the East, who had brought the lumber to build a good storm-resisting structure, Dad was ready with the cash, and 1702 Millington, also called Church Street, the last house on the east side of Millington, became our home and remains so today.

We always jokingly referred to the home as being in No man's Land, as there were no houses south and few east. Across Main Street, the first street west, lay the Commons, where circuses stretched their tents; and, at one time, a tribe of Indians camped for several months.

The larger house added much to Mother's very full schedule, as her duties as County Superintendent required a great deal of her time and kept her away often, so a maid was employed, no other than Dora Thorp, still living in Winfield as Mrs. Wise. She was very kind and capable; nevertheless, the days were too long for Bonnie and Louis, little more than babies, and Mother was gone so much.

In 1891 I graduated, which gave me an opportunity to be in home more and, in a manner, hold the fort while Mother launched her second campaign for re-election. Her opponent believed every thing was fair in politics and started many ugly stories about Mother. The most telling fraud was the propaganda circulated by the opposing candidate that Mother didn't need the office: she was a rich woman; she lived in a big house. "Why, she carries a silver mug along on her trips. She is too stuck up to drink out of common tin cups offered her."

There was only part truth in the gossip. Mother did carry her own drinking cup, and it was silver; not, however, because she wanted it so, but that it was the only one she had to use in this way.

So, due to much mud slinging together with Mother's indifference to re-election, her second campaign lacked the effort and enthusiasm necessary, and she went down in defeat, losing out by only seven votes. This she could have contested had she wished to do

so, but I'm sure the winning candidate was not happier than Mother in her loss. She was a home body; she had four children to rear and educate, two of them mere babies, and in those days there were no "baby sitters". Her family needed her more than mere added shekels were necessary to the bank account.

And talking of children, Mother belonged to the so-called old school. She was reared when one's best prized possession, particularly a girl's, was a lovely, white skin, without blemish or make-up. And the most ruinous factors were sun and wind. No girl would think of stopping out-of-doors without wearing her sunbonnet; and, if March winds were high, the kind that "tans the girls", in all probability a heavy beige veil would be tied over the uncomfortable headgear. Not a breath of wind must come in direct contact with the soft white cheek, nor a ray of sun be allowed to burn it. And hands, too, must be white and snowy, protected by heavy half-handers. Quite naturally, when Mother's babies were growing, they must be protected, too, from the ravages of sun and wind. Their complexions should be kept soft and white. No tan or freckles should spoil the beauty of her children, not if she had anything to do with it. Sometimes it was a bit difficult to keep sunbonnets on their rebellious heads, but that could be overcome by, as in Harry's case, tying a lock of hair to the crown of the offending wearing apparel. How he hated those bonnets! But Mother was adamant, and her beautifully fair-skinned boy remained so. Yesterday and today. Progress?

Yes, Mother was a home body, domestic we call it, and now that she no longer had the problems of the county's educational system on her shoulders, "happy days were here again". We could gather around the fire on winter evenings to popcorn and crack nuts, and in summer freeze ice cream on the cellar steps or eat watermelon out on the well curb.

Of course there was a cow, a pen of chickens, and horses in the barn. There were no electric lights, telephones, nor was there city water. No automobile, but there was a roomy two-seated carriage; and, of all things, a colored coachman to drive it. We must have been quite classy, driving to parties and making calls.

Mother, too, was free to enjoy the social side of life. It was in 1890 she organized her Coffee Club, known as the C.R.C.-- Coffee and Repartee Club-- She invited five of her friends, her especial friends, for an afternoon of visiting and fancywork. During the afternoon, they discussed with her the forming of a group for study and relaxation. Each invited guest was to ask her own best-loved friend, and in that way the membership of twelve would be entirely congenial. It was thus the Coffee and Repartee Club was born and continued to be Mother's greatest pride and joy for fifty-one years. At the time of disbandment, there were still living three of the original members: Mother, Mrs. Myra

McGregor, and Mrs. George Seward. If these old walls could talk they would tell of wonderful times these young matrons had and the joys of being together during their advancing years. Those dinner parties! The banquets, when husbands were invited to join them! How well I remember them and the serving of which I had much to do. Oh, those four and five course dinners!

About this time Rossetti Circle was organized, Mother as one of the organizers and a charter member, becoming their first president. Then, shortly after, she became one of a committee to organize the town's first music club, which was named APOLLO. Today it has been merged with Philharmonic and renamed the Winfield Music Club.

In 1897 Rossetti Club had grown to be quite large. Mother, though pregnant, prepared her duty for the year's program, as she sat out on the comfortable large porch, which Dad had enlarged to accommodate his "increasing family". The days were warm, just the kind that were conducive to day dreaming and quiet planning of her club duty. What subject she was to discuss was, no doubt of her own choosing, anyhow, she decided to tell her story by weaving into the theme the names of all club members. This proved to be no easy task, but a delightful one, and must have been well received. When she had given her paper, Meddie Hamilton, also a member, said:

"You surely will have a highly precocious child", which, of course, she did. The child of their "old age" this baby was to be, as Harry had married in 1893 and already had a son, nearing three. I, too, had been married nearly a year; Bonnie was fourteen, and Louis, twelve. No wonder the stork kicked up such a fuss, not only in the family, but among friends.

When the baby arrived, October 16, 1897, Mother and Dad had their third little girl, a lovely child, who proved to be as predicted, highly precocious.

"What shall we name her," Mother said.

"You promised your Coffee and Repartee Club you would name her so her initials would be C.R.C. Don't you remember?" I asked. "You are the president of the Rossetti Club, why don't you call her Christine Rossetti, then she would be named for both clubs."

Mother was delighted with the idea, so Christine Rossetti she was christened, and what a trail of happy events followed. The C.R.C., of course, was much flattered as well as pleased, and sent the mother and baby gorgeous flowers. Rossetti, to use the present-day slang, "went all out", sending a half dozen sterling silver spoons, engraved with C.R.C. To add another note, Mrs. Lamport, secretary of the club at the time, wrote a letter to William Rossetti, telling of the birth of the club baby, born to their president of Rossetti Club, named for his illustrious sister, and of the naming of the baby Christine

Rossetti, not only honoring his sister, but the entire Rossetti family. Very soon a letter came from William Rossetti, thanking the club for their gracious thought in telling him of what they had done. Enclosed with his letter was one of his sister's, written many years before, sent as a special gift to her namesake, Christine Rossetti Caton.

Christine was, indeed, a club baby, and Mother at forty-five had her third family. First, Harry, Flora and Lottie, then ten years later, Bonnie and Louis, and now, twelve years later, Chirstine, who became an aunt to a nephew nearly three years older than she, and three nieces practically her own age, Hortense, Julia, and Emily.

A baby in the family, tho her household schedule was running smoothly, changed Mother's activities materially, and for sometime her work with W.C.T.U., Rossetti, and Apollo, also C.R.C. lagged, especially in the Aid Society, the Missionary Society and her church and Sunday Scool attendance. Then, too, she had a young lady daughter(Bonnie) in college, studying music with all the intensity of a genius; she had baking, cleaning, sewing for a family of five, any one of which was enough to erase some of her interest in outside aticities.

These were the days when citizens went to the polls and voted to elect a mayor. It so happened the cause of Prohibition was the major issue; and Harry, running on that ticket, was elected and became the youngest mayor ever elected in Winfield.

True to his vows to work against and, if possible, close the joints, as the illegal, behind-closed-doors bars were called; the days, tense with anxiety, not only for Mother, but for all the family, as Harry's life had been threatened. Not only threatened but an attempt was made to end it. Anxious days, indeed, when one hot summer night, as he and his wife were preparing for bed, a shot rang through the room, just missing him by a few inches.

Mother's first-born an officer in daily danger, a baby in arms, and in between two half-grown children in their formative years, mentally, physically, spiritually, and educationally, dumped upon her shoulders no easy job. But her pioneer spirit was undaunted in her home as in her civic interests. Dad was the captain; Mother, the lieutenant; but she was, as always, the queen of her houshold, and still in her advanced years remains the queen mother.

Her enviable health and remarkable endurance were, no doubt, definite factors in her ability to accomplish so much and keep so many "irons in the fire". Her table always groaned with the best of food, and unexpected guests were ever welcome and found a gracious hostess, who seemed to wave a wand over the cook stove and a delicious meal was on the table. Those, too, were the days when a fire must be built with cobs or wood or coal, and one's friends dropped in unannounced, bringing all the children, to spend

the day, or Dad walked in with a customer or two. Oh, those were the days! But no matter how hot the day or the stove, how crowded with duties, Mother never permitted Dad to come home for a meal at noon or night to find her in *deshabille*. Her hair was nicely combed; and, if she had no time to change into a fresh dress, at least, there was a pretty clean apron.

Mother believed the drudgery of housework belonged to the morning; the afternoon should be devoted to reading, study, sewing, and friends. If, however, it was housecleaning time, (those were the days before hard floors and rugs made the change of seasons a matter of routine), when afternoon came, leaving much to be done, Mother first changed her dress for the afternoon, made herself ready for any unexpected guest, then went ahead with whatever work was left to do. That was why no one ever caught Mother unprepared to receive any and all visitors. Still, at her advanced age, the same routine is followed; in fact, a day that passes without her changing from her morning garb into what she chooses to call her afternoon clothes, is something that does not happen. When Dad lived, she dressed for him, now that he is gone, she dresses for her sons. Should Harry or Louis drop in for a visit before she has her hair combed and a dress on she knows they admire, her day is spoiled.

Mother has ever been the center, the pivot, around which all activities were planned. If friends came to visit, our first duty was to introduce them to her, also to Dad, if he wished, though usually he left us to Mother's approval. As I have remarked before, "If these old walls could talk; if they had ears," which no doubt they do, what peals of laughter would echo down the years, always with Mother's voice mingled with that of her children. How she loved young people! And she insisted that we bring our friends home. How often Harry came bursting in with a boy or two in tow, saying:

"Mama, I've brought the boys home for dinner," To be sure he had a steak, a nice juicy one--they were plentiful then at twenty-five cents a pound, or cheaper--which he knew would be an acceptable addition to what he knew would be ready.

These old tales seem more reminiscent than just the high lights of Mother's colorful years; but they cannot be omitted, as she was the center around which everything revolved. It is not rare to have an old-time friend come for a surprise visit, after many long years of so-journeying in some far-off land to say: "How well I remember the doughnuts you made, and how we devoured them." The time when Judge George McDermott, Louis' closest boyhood friend, and as free in our home as though he were Mother's own son; in fact, he called her "other mother" came with his children for a drop-in visit. The years were erased, and he was a boy again, delighted to show his little folk just where the cookie jar stood and "always was full." And the sad day, when the dozen red

American Beauty roses were brought from his funeral for "his other mother". Sad and sweet memories closely interwoven with Mother and her life.

Nothing ever seemed too hard for her to do if it brought anyone pleasure, which recalls the Sunday afternoon, long before any of us were married and Christine was unheard of, when, as usual, the porch was crowded with family and friends. Among those visiting were Claude Martin and Maude Emory, our intimate friends before they were Dr. and Mrs. Claude Martin, and Claude was not Winfield's leading dentist.

It was very, very hot, but we were all young, including Mother. When five o'clock came, the hour the chickens were allowed to range on the lawn before going to roost. Looking out on the contented flock, Claude said:

"If I catch two of those chickens, will you fry them?"

Mother rose to the challenge and declared that if he could catch them, she could and would cook them. Of course, they were caught, and soon we all gathered around the big dining table, chattering like magpies and eating as only husky youngsters can. The luscious cake of Saturday's baking was in the offing and a freezer of delicious ice cream, made with eggs, laid, perhaps, by the very chickens on the platter before us, and the rich Jersey cream from our faithful cow. Happy times, full of light banter. Never a dull moment when Mother was around, and she always was.

These were the days when the Chautauqua was in its infancy, conceived by the "Intelligensia" of our thriving little city of Winfield and supported by stockholders, of whom Dad was one. To review the twenty-five years of Chautauqua, how it began and flourished; to tell only a few of the joys experienced in that "tent city" in Island Park, would be a departure from Mother's individual coming and going. But a true picture cannot be given of her characteristics without recording, in passing, what a wealth of mental stimulus the two weeks of study each summer and the contacts with educational groups brought her. Her constant search for knowledge, her love of books, her joy in exchange of ideas with others of her same mental ability, not only stimulated her urge for advancement, but was most gratifying.

Surely the human family has grown soft. Today they must ride everywhere. Yesterday, they walked. Yes, all the way from 1702 Millington to Island Park, not once a day, but often two or three times, through scorching sun or drizzle of rain. But what prizes lay at the point of destination! Perhaps Talmage, Gonsalus, Bryan, or a symphony orchestra. And to miss it---well, we just didn't do that. Whatever the weather, no lecture should be missed; no matter how profound the subject, right next to Mother sat her children. One always could play; only once in a lifetime could one hear a famous lectur-

er. Through Mother we were constantly surrounded by an atmosphere of culture, unappreciated at the time, but what a heritage for which to be grateful.

These were the days of the "gay nineties": days of stiff corsets, hoop skirts and bustles, and hidden extremities. Days, when Mother, doing her own work, must see to it that her girls had plenty of starched petticoats, all tucked and ruffled and lace-trimmed, which were, according to fashion, worn by two's and three's. Normal days of no particular incidents worthy of recording. Children were well and growing. Life was turning on its daily axis. Dad was accumulating comfortably. There was an abundance of food in the larder. Routine of day followed day: friends, clubs; everything running along smoothly. Then---

Christine fell ill of diphtheria; and, only by the miracle of anti-toxin, which at the time was almost too new and hazardous in which to place one's faith, was she saved. Before normalcy had been restored and the shock of the frightening experience lessened, Louis became ill, a victim of the dread malady. With him the disease took a serious form, leaving him slightly paralyzed in his limbs, which condition lasted for several weeks. Then down went Bonnie; however, her attack was light. Of course, Dad was kept away; but Mother remained on duty with her three dangerously ill children. The siege was long and harrowing, but trouble, being "born a twin", was not ready to move on. Before the quarantine had been lifted, scarlet fever set in, and each in turn suffered the run of this alarming disease. For weeks, yes months, Mother went from one to the other, a prisoner under quarantine, tired and mentally distracted. Long, long weeks of confinement, but coming to an end with a note of thankfulness, as all recovered with no ill or trace of any defects; such as, deafness or blindness, which quite often occurred in those days before today's preventives: sulfa drugs, penicillin, and many others with which we are familiar in these scientific times.

No first-aid instruction, no nurse's training, just mother love and constant care brought them through. Why Mother did not contract either disease remains a mystery; how she endured the strain of such trying experience, is still another mystery and added proof of her excellent health, her untiring devotion to her family, and her unbreakable strength. Dad, in his usual light banter, declared he was going to expose them to small-pox, then they never need fear any further quarantine.

Aside from this unhappy interval, life at 1702 Millington moved along with the times. Through the years the face of the old homestead had changed gradually. The walls had been pushed out; the porches doubled in size; the horses removed from the barn--automobiles had come to town--the cow was gone; and, since the chickens no longer roamed the lawn, the picket fence had disappeared. Winfield had been trans-

formed into a sanitary city, boasting natural gas, city water, electricity, and the telephone. Lamps were relegated to the basement or the trash heap. Latrines moved into the bathroom, where the old galvanized tub had been exchanged for a snowy white porcelain one, equipped with faucets for hot and cold water. Electric lights flared at the touch of a button, and the old iron cook stove was carried off to give place to a gas range.

Thus, though the house was much larger, the work was easier, and Mother had more time to devote to her flowers. Next to her books, her one passion was flowers, all kinds: roses, perennials, many more than she could easily care for. Countless hours were needed for the work in her garden, but there was always a bouquet for the table every month in the year.

The American Beauty climber, that burst into rotous bloom in early spring, twining its graceful tendrils over the arch to the driveway, attracted so much admiration, it was not unusual to glance out the window to see an art class at work reproducing the beauty spot. Yes---

*My mother's garden was rambling and gay.
Beautiful. Exotic. And every day
She was there, when the first rosy streak of morn
'Roused the nodding bud and prickly thorn.*

To one nearing sixty the care of a child of nine, the adjustment from so-called old-fashioned rules of life, old-fashioned in that changes always seem somehow tinged with a lack of culture, presented quite a problem to Mother. Could she give her young, precocious child a free rein? Let her grow according to the trends of the times, free and unconscious of her beauty and talent, touching that of genius? Mother's one thought during her pregnancy was that this child should be talented and beautiful, equal that of one of her favorites, Neilson, who was very popular at the time. Many times she has said: "I thought Christine would sing."

However, despite Mother's hopes and wishes, her baby, though talented in many ways, excelled in piano and composition. In fact, Mother could rightfully be proud of both Bonnie and Christine. Each carried away the state prize in piano, just ten years apart, making it rather difficult to deny that inheritance plays a big part, and that "blood is thicker than water". Were their musical talents accidental? Was Louis' gift of art the same? Was Harry's urge to make everything exactly to the line, resulting in his becoming an architect, where the intricacies of the blue-print gratified his greatest desire, was it not traceable to that Chief Architect to the king? Who can say?

This seems a digression from Mother, but how can one recount the high lights of her life and completely separate her from her children. Her life is reflected in them and woven about them and their ambitions and progress. She grows with them, suffers with them and for them, and rejoices over their joys, and humbly thanks God for them. Their accomplishments are dearer to her than had she earned honor. Though she never has bowed her head in shame over one of us, not one of us has quite equaled her, nor dared hoped to do so. She has endowed each with the heritage of a wonderful mother, for which we are truly grateful and rightfully proud; but, as for rising to her social and religious place in the community, not one has or can hope to do so. A pioneer, a teacher in the city schools, superintendent of county schools, organizer of several clubs, as much at home on the speaker's platform as in her own living room, a good wife, the mother of six children, who never was known to go to bed when one of them was out for the evening, no matter how late the hour of return; in fact, the only mean thing she ever did was to set the standard so high not one of us could quite reach it.

Both Bonnie and Louis chose 1906 as the year of their marriage; Louis in June; Bonnie in October, which left Christine, at nine, alone with Mother and Dad, practically an only child. No doubt, Mother's months of strain during the long siege of illness, which Christine, Bonnie, and Louis had suffered, had reduced Mother more than anyone suspected. At least, at this time, she faced her first and greatest tragedy. At her age, it was not anything of which to be unduly alarmed just to find that her eyes were suggesting that glasses would much improve her vision.

"You must get your eyes tested for glasses," Dad warned.

"Yes, I guess you are right," Mother admitted, knowing her eyes were giving her much trouble; but, like all of us, dreading the ordeal of getting accustomed to glasses. So, after some hesitation, she consulted an Optometrist, who, after examining her, said:

"There is something peculiar about your eyes, which I do not fully understand. A specialist would catch it much more quickly than I. I suggest that you consult one."

So Mother consulted a specialist, who no doubt, meant well, but, unfortunately, was altogether too blunt in reporting his findings. "You have lost the sight of one eye, and the other will go out within a year, due in a measure to sympathy."

Blind! Within a year! No, it couldn't be true! Too much work lay ahead that required her eyes! That she didn't go blind was, indeed, a miracle; for she came near crying her eyes out, then she packed up her courage and did the sensible thing; she consulted another specialist, who found she had something peculiar about her vision, but that astigmatism was her greatest trouble, fitted her with glasses, saving not only her sight but her sanity. Once more she could read; and, at the advanced age of eighty-seven, was able

to read her much-loved "Upper Room" and her daily Bible study. There was some difficulty, of course, but she could keep apace with her growing daughter, her school, her music, her clothes, and her admirers, which, to be sure, added up quite a problem in modern adjustment.

World War I precipitated Christine's early marriage, as her sweetheart was an officer in training and expected to be sent overseas at any time.

Mothers are all alike, always breathless over the prospect of a daughter's marriage; but Christine's hurry-up affair: a wedding to be accomplished within three days--bridal apparel, (she simply couldn't be married in anything but white), plans for the wedding breakfast, the going-away outfit, engraved announcements, the hurried get-together of linens and bedding, suitable decorations for a home wedding for a bride in white--all these and many more produced no small ruffle in the family, and surely brought on a near storm upon the calm waters of the household.

It was just another of the obstacles one sweeps aside somehow as the wheels of life turn. So Mother's baby was married, lovely in sheer white, before a bower of palms and flowers arranged by the florist, saying her vows to the soft strains of nuptial music: and was whisked away, after a tempting wedding breakfast, to live for six happy months before the dread order came. It had to come, the moment hung like an executioner's axe over the necks of the newly-weds. When, at last, the suspense was over and the sad day of parting had come and gone, Mother had her baby at home again.

Months dragged along, made up of days of watching the casualty lists, beating a path to the mail box, fighting off fear of that official envelope; then, one very hot summer afternoon, thirteen months later than the scorching July day of her wedding, August 25, 1918; to keep dates correct, Frank Pletcher Root, Jr. announced his arrival with a lusty wail. Christine's son was born, and 1702 Millington checked up another happy affair; and, too, the family Bible recorded the birth of a son in the same home in which his mother had been born and had lived to womanhood.

Again the old walls caught the sound of a baby's voice, that would echo down through the years; and Mother had another grandson to add to her rapidly growing number.

At the close of World War I, or about that time, on March 25, 1919, Mother's and Dad's fiftieth wedding anniversary fell due. No mention was to be made of it, for Dad would "have none of it." However, the best man at their run-away marriage, Billie Talleferro, with his wife, whom he married soon after Dad's and Mother's elopement, came to be with them on this happy day; and, indeed, it was a happy day. All we children, except Bonnie, who lived too far away to come, were here. Though no one was to

be told, there were lovely flowers from friends; a chest of Sterling silver, Dad's gift, which somehow had failed to arrive on the twenty-fifth anniversary, also some lovely linen, which we children added to round out the celebration. And did that four-yard banquet cloth come in handy, when the dining table, stretched to its ample length, groaned with every good thing that could be found; the huge turkey, looking so delicious and as important as a king inspecting his silver and crystal? My, the turkeys Grandmother baked! And her tempting dressing! What wonderful times! Happy times, beginning when there were only four around the board, Dad, Mother, Harry and Lottie, and continuing Christmas after Christmas until twenty-six happy, noisy individuals, all talking at once, all eyes on Grandfather, who took so much time to carve that turkey just right, sat around the table.

It was a tradition we hoped never would be broken: Dad at the head of the table, Mother, always beaming and smiling, at the opposite end, and all the children and grandchildren in the places where they were accustomed to sit. The eldest and the youngest must be at the table, if that meant holding the latest edition in arms. It just wasn't Christmas without turkey dinner at Grandmother's.

Time, of course, takes its toll, and these happy times had to end; but what lovely memories and exquisite joys in reminiscing. After all we had devoured many turkeys during all those years until Mother was eighty-five, when she baked her last turkey and acted as hostess to her fast-increasing family.

When seventy-two, Mother travelled to New York state to visit Bonnie and her family. It so happened that Mrs. Crapster, Louise's mother, was going to Philadelphia to visit her daughter Bretta and family and persuaded Mother to "come along".

It was August, not the most comfortable month for such a long journey, but I see Mother yet, as she started off, looking so smart and so young in her becoming dress of lavender sheer and a very particularly attractive hat.

I well remember that the sleeves were three-quarter and showed quite a little of her shapely white arms. Not at all shocking, but quite lovely, even in the eyes of her very fastidious son, Harry; who, when a mere lad, so proud of his pretty mother, stopped her as she started off to church, to exclaim:

"Mama, are you going to church in that dress?"

"Yes, of course," Mother answered. "What's wrong? Don't you like it."

"The dress is all right, but those sleeves!"

"And what's wrong with the sleeves. They're the latest."

"Why, they are lace, and your arms show through. My mother shouldn't wear such clothes; they're not decent," insisted Harry.

No doubt Mother looked very chic in her gold and black checked silk with its transparent sleeves, and the fashionable high-crowned leghorn hat, faced with black velvet and trimmed with two soft, white plumes. But, lest she turn a few susceptible male worshippers' heads and scandalize her adoring son, she went back and changed into something less ultra in which to go to church, retaining her chastity, at least in the eyes of her young son. When time permitted, she removed the offending yoke and sleeves, replacing them with the silk. Of course, it completely transformed the outfit, but her son was concerned and displeased, so never again would she be caught in such attire. And she was only thirty. How time changes one's point of view.

Her trip through the eastern states was most enjoyable: the trees, the lush verdure, the lakes, Niagara Falls, even the climate, all were new and exciting. Just to be with Bonnie, whom she had not seen for several years, and her seven little children, all added up to a delightful time. The only fly in the ointment was the children's disappointment when they first saw Mother.

"We thought our grandmother was coming to see us," was the first surprising exclamation. "She's not a grandmother", which pictures Mother at seventy-two better than any adjectives I can select....alert, vivacious, deeply interested in people, a fluent talker, with that enviable ability to converse equally well with the most distinguished in station, or the humblest.

And what a blessed privilege it was to visit Bonnie in her own home and surroundings; go with her to the places she loved best; meet the friends she cherished, and see her with her beautiful children. Blessed, indeed, but at the time, and fortunately, too, she did not realize she was collecting indelible pictures of her last visit with that happy family.

On the Seventh of December, 1923, at two o'clock in the morning, the unearthly hour of a cold winter dawn, when life is at its lowest ebb, the phone buzzed harshly. Buzzed again and again, then Mother realized she was not dreaming, but that in truth her phone was ringing. It was an ominous peal that sent her blindly to pick up the receiver.

"This is 930. Who is calling?" Mother questioned, only half awake.

"This is the telegraph office. We have a message for you. Shall we read it?"

"Yes, do," was Mother's breathless answer.

There was a moment's hesitancy, then quite slowly the operator read: 'Bonnie died last night. Signed Charles.'

Shocks such as that prove one a pillar of strength or a weakling; and Mother was no weakling. There were frantic hours before such news could be fully realized. The family

must be told. There were decisions to be made. Who could go? Did anyone dare venture into the bitter weather that was sweeping New York at the time? Mother's and Dad's years prevented such a risk; Harry was just recovering from a serious siege of pneumonia; Louis had no one to leave at the dairy, and I was just up from a severe case of flu. Christine could make the trip, but that was not thought best; so, after hours of consultation, each one offering to take the risk, Dad settled the indecision by using his veto and arguing that Bonnie was gone. What Charles needed was burial expenses, his being a minister and very short on funds. That argument held, and the money was dispatched. But, of course, that was only the beginning of our grief, Mother's especially. She went right on, busying herself almost frantically, bravely accepting. The months that followed, however, took their toll, as months of deep sorrow always do in one way or another.

Her eyes that always sparkled were not quite so bright. There were a few more gray hairs, and her sunny countenance lost some of its brightness, but not for long. She had so "many blessings": her children, her friends, and her church. Life must go on. Were there not now two daughters waiting on the other side. She must be brave for Dad's sake.

In Church, as in all Mother's interests, she found some especial work to be done. When she became a member of the Methodist Church, for instance, she found a desperate need for some activities to interest the young people. They needed something to tie to in their religious life; something of a social nature. Just to know this meant that Mother would do something about it, and that something was the organization of the Queen Esther Circle. In 1880 she planted this seed and in 1947 it remains one of the outstanding young people's societies.

Mother enjoyed all church work, the Aid and Missionary, but her one great love was her Sunday School class, the King's Daughters. She would much rather miss the church service than to fail to be in her place in her class. Whatever she did, whatever she undertook, she worked at it with all her might.

Her faithful, untiring work in the Missionary Society and in the Aid, lately reorganized into the Women's Society of Christian Service(WSCS) earned for her a life membership "in appreciation of fifty years' service." Life has a way of playing some mean tricks. Now that years were pushing so close together, and her church activities were waning, a life membership is presented to her. Just the irony of life; however, the honor gave her great pleasure, and was a very much appreciated reward.

Only occasionally could she endure the sharp pain of every step she took to reach her place in the church service; however, she was ninety before she resigned herself to the inevitable and admitted that age had at last moved in, and she could no longer carry

on as before. Then, too, her dimming eyes and impaired hearing were making the effort too great.

There were many hours of grief and no little struggle at reinforcing her fortitude before she could accept this graciously and substitute the radio sermon for the one at her church. With her alert mind and keen sense of values, she summed it up with these very pertinent words:

"My lack of sight is my affliction; my deafness is everybody's.

When yet a young woman, Mother was subject to acute stomach attacks, very sudden ones, at least that was the diagnosis of her doctor, who insisted on walking in answer to a call and was religiously opposed to haste. Thus, by the time he arrived on the scene, Mother was, as a rule, thanks to the hurried efforts of anyone who happened to be near, often kind neighbors, much improved. These attacks aggravated by overwork, mental strain, or coming often after a club meeting, when she had eaten some indigestible morsel, became very frequent. Mother always worked fast and furiously in order to get all her irons out of the fire. Dad insisted she was the only woman who could do four things at a time and do them all well: rock a cradle, sing a lullaby, read a book, and keep her knitting needles clicking right along. But, of course, these attacks were not due to any nervous haste, but "those oysters and that rich dessert you had at the club," Dad invariably declared.

Not until Mother was seventy-five, and we came very near losing her, was it discovered that this distressing, long-time malady was gall bladder trouble, superinduced by undue excitement and nervousness. At this time, she became so desperately ill, consultation was called, a nurse installed, and for days the family sat on the anxious seat. Nevertheless, with her usual reserve strength, she recovered rapidly, and not in eighteen years has such an attack returned.

Before Mother was fully recovered from this serious illness, and her strength had returned, she was called upon to face her most crucial test: the news of Christine's mental lapse, brought on by an accident, a severe blow on her head that had been treated lightly at the time, but resulted so seriously, even tragically.

The news of her serious condition fell like a bomb into our midst. X-RAY had traced the trouble to pressure on the brain, and only an operation could save her sanity. Only those who have known the blackness of despair could in any way understand the utter desperation of the mother heart at such a moment, especially, as no one was to be allowed to see or visit Christine, not even Mother. Neither were there to be any "disturbing letters of inquiry", not for a whole year. Perhaps not then. What took place normally

during those unforgettable days, remains a blank. Days were lived only for reports, which, when they came, held little hope. "No change". "Not so good today."

Hope. Without hope life holds nothing. Did Mother cease to hope? Did she cease to pray? Did she lose faith? Not Mother. God watched over all, and He would watch over her baby, as Christine has never ceased to be.

The shock of Bonnie's sudden passing had seemed almost more than Mother could endure; but it was only a preparation for this, her pinnacle of grief. The anxiety! The days of hopeless despair! Only those nearest knew that beneath the unbroken tenor of her daily life lay a heart in turmoil of agony, crushed and bleeding. Likewise, only the nearest to her could rejoice with her; and, with her, thank God for Christine's complete recovery. True, nearly two years had elapsed, and during that time there were days when faith became all too ragged at the edges, and those of sane mind knew that nothing short of a miracle, in the hands of a skilled surgeon, could rebuild the brain tissue, "as good as new." Those who watched the delicate fingers of the surgeon, guided and strengthened by unseen Power, were privileged to witness a miracle.

Reaction from a strain such as this brought on what seemed uneventful days, that hurried along so rapidly Mother was eighty before we realized it. Not young according to the calendar, but certainly not old. Her step was as brisk as ever; her figure unchanged, and her interest in church, civic and club life as keen as ever. When at eighty-three she appeared before the high school assembly to play the music of her girlhood and to tell them, in her fluent, easy way, of the difference between the educational system when she was a student, and that which they were enjoying, we could but wonder when old age would catch up with her. How those youngsters thrilled at the skill with which she played her girlhood favorite: THE MAIDEN'S PRAYER; and that ripply affair: THE FAMILY POLKA. The point is that when she requested some one of the many students of piano to play, showing the great change in musical trends, there was not one who would volunteer.

In her eighty-seventh year, Rossetti held their home-coming program in the Methodist Church; and, Mother, as their first vice president, was given a place of honor on the platform, and extended the courtesy of telling them some of the interesting facts of the early days. Completely at ease, as always without notes, and looking very lovely in her black and white dress and most becoming lavender hat with its crown of violets, one had to stretch her imagination to associate her with any such advanced years.

And now the wedding anniversaries. They were beginning to cause much in the way of news items. Why, the fiftieth was nothing. All the sixties had been passed over without any especial notice. She and Dad were growing older every day; and, as anniversaries

simply meant that more years had been lived in health and as much happiness as comes to the average persons, and that was all. But seventy, seventy-one, seventy-two and both Mother and Dad active and in good health, well, that was something to cause some comment.

Dad would have nothing whatsoever to do about them; but friends, they were different. Cards, flowers, gifts, telegrams, one in particular from the Governor, congratulating them on their long life together and mentioning that upon investigation, he had learned they were the only couple in Kansas living together so long; in fact, he was not sure there was any other couple in the United States to equal them.

Dad, always full of fun, declared that when their seventy-fifth anniversary arrived, he would hire a carriage, lay back the top, have it drawn by four snow white horses, with trappings silver tipped; and he and Mother, seated in this lovely Victorian equipage, would ride up and down the length of Main Street, bands playing, flags flying. There was no use celebrating anything less than the diamond anniversary.

Yes, Dad was going to live to be a hundred; but the Reaper decided differently. At ninety-three, just a few weeks before he reached his ninety-fourth year, he slipped away. The diamond anniversary, with all its fan-fare, as Dad had planned it, became the myth he had pictured. The long companionship was ended, coming suddenly to a close on August Twenty-second, 1941. The familiar, white-haired figure, sitting out on the spacious porch in the sturdy chair, rocking for hours, "just waiting" had disappeared. The staccato click of his cane, resounding through the rooms, was stilled. Taps were sounded for the last Civil War Veteran of Winfield out on the hillside cemetery, where he had first viewed and loved the little western town.

And Mother---the years ahead. What did they hold for her? How long would she have to walk alone? Could she make the adjustment, meeting whatever came day by day? All questions one naturally asks when the Reaper's scythe cuts down the one nearest and dearest. But when one has reached the eighty-ninth milestone and has lived seventy-two of them with her chosen companion, the journey ahead looms bleak and dark and dreary.

There was no alarming hysteria, no lessening of her courage, only the chalk-white face, as she accepted the beautiful flag, which had draped Dad's bier, and was presented to her as his "next of kin", betrayed the emotion too deep for tears.

Once, quite foolishly, I allowed a Spiritualist to read my fortune. Naturally, she could tell me all the things that had happened in my past life, which, of course, I knew only too well, as to the future, only God knows that. What interested me, however, was what she told me of my parents..... they would grow to be quite old. They were very closely

knit, so much so, that when one passed, the other would follow soon, perhaps within a year. Thinking this something pleasant to carry along, I repeated what had been revealed to me, which proved to be a mistake. Mother never forgot it. She was convinced when Dad left us, she would not linger long. Perhaps the thought sustained her during those first disheartening days. I like to think so.

But with excellent health, an alert mind, there were many milestones left for her to pass. And, too, there was all the "red tape" to unwind with Uncle Sam at one end, Mother at the other; long-drawn-out correspondence to establish her claim to a pension as Dad's widow.

Four months elapsed, during which time a photostatic copy of the page in the family Bible, recording their marriage, was submitted; also the Governor's telegram and the newspaper clippings of their seventy-second anniversary; but Uncle Sam needed more. Further questions were asked. There was no record of their marriage license, as a fire in the Missouri Courthouse, where it had been secured, had destroyed all records of that year.

Friends began to chuckle and tease: "Has your Mother proved she's a decent woman yet!"

In truth, it seemed her legality never would be established, when one day, as I was looking through Dad's papers, I found a questionnaire he had filled out some years before. One line jumped out at me. There in Dad's bold handwriting lay the answer we sought.

"Are you married"? the questionnaire demanded.

"Yes," was filled in properly, as all that was required, but Dad had more to say. Interlining the question was the proof we had been searching:

"I married Julia Blankenmeister, the only woman I ever married." And that established Mother as Dad's legal wife, his widow, entitled to a widow's pension.

When one reaches ninety, birthdays attract attention; it is a matter about which one boasts. Friends crowd about; gifts, cards, perhaps as many as a hundred, arrive, and flowers come to brighten the day. It's news. But ninety-one, ninety-two---really that is an occasion, an outstandingly lovely one. A day of days, when Mother, attractive in her bright dress, her white hair soft about her face, her bright eyes sparkling with joy, held court; her living room the gathering place of young and old alike, and Mother the youngest of all.

*How does it seem to be ninety-two,
Knee-deep in myriad memories,*

*That time has tinted in pastel hue,
Priceless as costly old tapestries?*

*Sacred, fragile, sweet rememberings:
Broad winding roads along life's pathway,
Strewn with rose leaves; bits of worn heart strings.....
Love and romance of your wedding day.*

*Drifting, dreaming, lost in faint echoes,
Tossed by bright rainbows from hill to hill
You climbed, nor paused, though deep wintry snows
Hid your guide posts and bid heart be still.*

*Ninety-two milestones of vanished years---
Challenging, golden, God-given, well
Nurtured by hope and washed in tears,
Strong as the walls of a citadel.*

*Near a century to watch unfold
Youth's perplexities and fondest dream....
Great gift of years, yet you are not old
But young; a student of world regime.*

*Three seasons of life's cycle complete:
Spring's beauty, summer's joy and warmth, then
Autumn's gold. Now winter's bitter-sweet
To cherish until the last Amen.*

These few lines were a very poor contribution to such an auspicious occasion, but it was all I had, and Mother seemed pleased.

The same year, 1944, Mother was asked to bring to General Assembly of WSCS, held in the Methodist Church, a regime of its inception and growth.

By this time it was necessary for me to go along, as her hearing was much impaired, and I must tell her when it was time for her "to speak her piece". She had not heard what other speakers had included in their reports; yet, by some favor of the gods, Mother did not repeat any of the previous remarks; instead, she made a most interesting talk of past accomplishments of the "Aid", as it was called at the time it was organized, and did so entirely without notes.

It has ever been a source of astonishment that Mother's voice has lost none of its original quality, and that her choice of words, appropriate to the subject and occasion, were always on the tip of her tongue. This was so wonderfully demonstrated that same year, when she attended the fiftieth anniversary of Rossetti Club.

The meeting was held in the Community Council rooms; and, as usual, I tagged along as body guard--eyes and ears--in truth the necessary evil. We walked. Nine blocks, and Mother climbed without hesitation or trouble, the steps leading to the club room.

The hall was crowded with members and guests; the program rather long, but Mother sat quietly and waited until I indicated it was her time to speak. And how she talked! What a wealth of reminiscence her memory unfolded to her interested listeners!

As she had not only been their first vice president but had drafted the club constitution, which remains today in its original draft as submitted, she was presented a life membership, of which she is, quite naturally, very proud.

It was thus, in her ninety-second year, Mother made her last public appearance. The effort of preparation was becoming a real burden, so more than eighty-nine years after she knitted the family stockings; in fact, she began so young, it seems she always has knitted, once again Mother is knitting; this time counting the hours by the click of her needles. Now, however, she makes only hot pads, but how valuable they are as helps to one, whose activities have been so greatly curtailed by Father Time.

So at her radio---blessing on the man who invented it---or should I say, blessings on Marconi and Uncle Sam, who so kindly furnishes the Record Reading Book machine for the blind? Days are now counted as just time passing, routine, the simple tasks of dressing herself or making her bed, which she insists on doing, though it has become a real effort. Looking back upon the days when she managed "to keep so many irons in the fire", her duties seem as almost nothing, yet they weary her as much or more than a full day's labor once did. Age surely takes its toll.

Her interest in conditions and people, however, has not changed, which, no doubt, sets her out from the crowd and keeps her friends crowding about her, both old and young, who, dropping in at any time, find her dressed to receive them. Indeed, it would be a matter of much concern did she fail to cream her face, comb her hair, and change to an afternoon dress not later than two-thirty.

Nearing the end of my very poor effort to leave an unbiased picture of Mother, she is anticipating her ninety-sixth milestone. For weeks before I was admonished not "to tell a soul". As though all the friends who had been making each birthday such a happy occasion would forget. So I didn't tell, but I quietly got ready. The house was in order. The punch bowl was full of frappe; Mother was in her prettiest dress, and the birthday cake

was the very loveliest one ever to grace the standard cake stand. And it was well all was in order, for early and late guests came to wish her happiness and insist that she would round out the century mark. But life, to be sure, is more or less just marking time, when one can count on one hand the years left before one hundred is reached, Like Dad she is "waiting"; however, unlike him, she loves everybody and everything: the radio, her knitting, people, and above all, her children. Her interest in them is keen indeed. Their comings and goings are uppermost in her mind. So time is racing with Mother, not dragging, as it did with Dad.

These jottings would hardly be complete were I to fail to tell of the "sittings" Mother has had. Sitting for her portrait, not once, but twice, and a third having her photograph enlarged to life size (the copy remains in its heavy walnut frame, though it no longer occupies space on the sitting room wall) Mother was only in her twenties when this photograph was taken, which, no doubt, was a very fine likeness, at least the photographer thought so, and through this enlargement established quite a reputation. The broad forehead, crowned with her wealth of soft brown braids, wound around her well-shaped head, the cut of the dress of the Seventies, and the long earrings, falling from pierced ears, prove the photographer an artist and Mother a true photogenic.

When she was in her thirties and one of Winfield's very pretty matrons--by that time I was on the scene--a friend from Topeka came to spend what today would be called a week-end visit. His fingers were itching to give expression to his urge to draw. He had great ambitions to become a famous artist, portrait painter; and Mother was a good subject, at least, for practice.

"Let me sketch your picture, Julia," he suggested, toying with his drawing pad.

Mother demurred, but gave in, and unknowingly became the first subject of a future famous portrait painter, George Stone, whose paintings hang in the Louvre. In Mother's tattered and torn scrapbook you will find this rather crude drawing, which, though earmarked as the work of an amateur, is an excellent likeness of her as a young woman, and gives definite hint of the genius that was to leave the world so much.

It was many years later, yes, many, many years later, when Mother was ninety-four, that she sat again for her portrait. This time it was done in oil by the rising young artist, John Hanlen. Claudine suggested the sitting as a Christmas gift to Chandler, and once again Mother needed persuasion, but finally she yielded, as it was to be for Chandler, and we all were so thrilled over the gracious compliment.

In her becoming black dress, her soft white hair carefully arranged, her diamond earrings glinting in her ears, Mother was the perfect patrician lady and an inspiring subject for the young artist. Chandler's letter of appreciation and his declaration of pride at be-

ing able to point to the portrait of his grandmother, "ninety-four", more than compensated for the strain of the hours the artist required.

Months and months, stretching into a year or more, have elapsed since I began compiling the material of so much interest to all of us, and Mother still carries on. "Getting up in the morning to go to bed at night", to quote her oft-time favorite remark. Watching for Harry's daily visit, Louis' and Louise's many drop-in calls, going back and forth to the mailbox for Christine's letters, enjoying the youth of her grandchildren and great-grandchildren, anticipating visits from her many friends, knitting a little, walking a few times around the porch, listening to her radio, declaring over and over that she is not going to live to be a hundred: these add up to each day's routine.

There will be another page to these memoirs, a blank page, which must be filled in, by whom I do not know. According to her friends, Mother is ageless; however, God's records are never wrong. He alone knows the day and the hour, when, with saddened hearts, we shall be called upon to write FINIS across the page, which will mean the beginning of the richness of memory of one of God's noble women, whom He so graciously selected to be our Mother.